shells were fired at the palace and that prompted the people around the Dalai Lama to prepare for his escape from Lhasa.

The uprising was brutally crushed by the PLA—but the Dalai Lama, escorted by resistance fighters, managed to slip out of the city under the cover of darkness at three o'clock in the morning. Their goal was to reach the Indian border. To what extent the CIA actually helped the Dalai Lama flee is still an open question, but they were certainly aware that he was heading for India in disguise within days of his escape from the Tibetan capital. Up in the mountains, the Dalai Lama's party caught up with the CIA's Tibetan resistance fighters inside Tibet, who were equipped with radios. They keyed a message to Okinawa, the US base on the Ryukyu Islands, which had not yet been handed back to Japan since their occupation during the final stages of World War II. The CIA also knew that the Dalai Lama, while on his way to the Indian border, had repudiated the 17-point agreement for 'the Peaceful Liberation of Tibet'.[103]

These messages from the CIA-trained Tibetan radio operators prompted the agency to ask India to grant the Dalai Lama asylum before he had reached the Indian border. The CIA's station chief in New Delhi went straight to Nehru with the request. After long deliberations about the possible negative impact of refusal on India's relations with the United States, the prime minister finally agreed, cutting layers of red tape to facilitate the process. Melinda Liu wrote in *Newsweek* in April 1999, 'A CIA-trained Tibetan even managed to film the odyssey with a 16-mm camera; it showed the spiritual leader, astride on a brown horse with richly embroidered saddlebags, and his retinue picking their way across Tibet's bleak hillsides, with the People's Liberation Army breathing down their necks.'[104]

On 30 March 1959, the Dalai Lama and his men crossed the last mountain pass on the border between Khenzemane and Zeimithang, northwest of Tawang. From there, weak from dysentery, the Dalai Lama rode into the salient Tawang, a green area in the rugged mountains, where he was met by Indian government officials and army personnel. He was safe. He and his entourage continued down to Tezpur in the Assam plains, where a media frenzy awaited him. The 24-year-old God King of Tibet had fled from communist China, and that was world news.